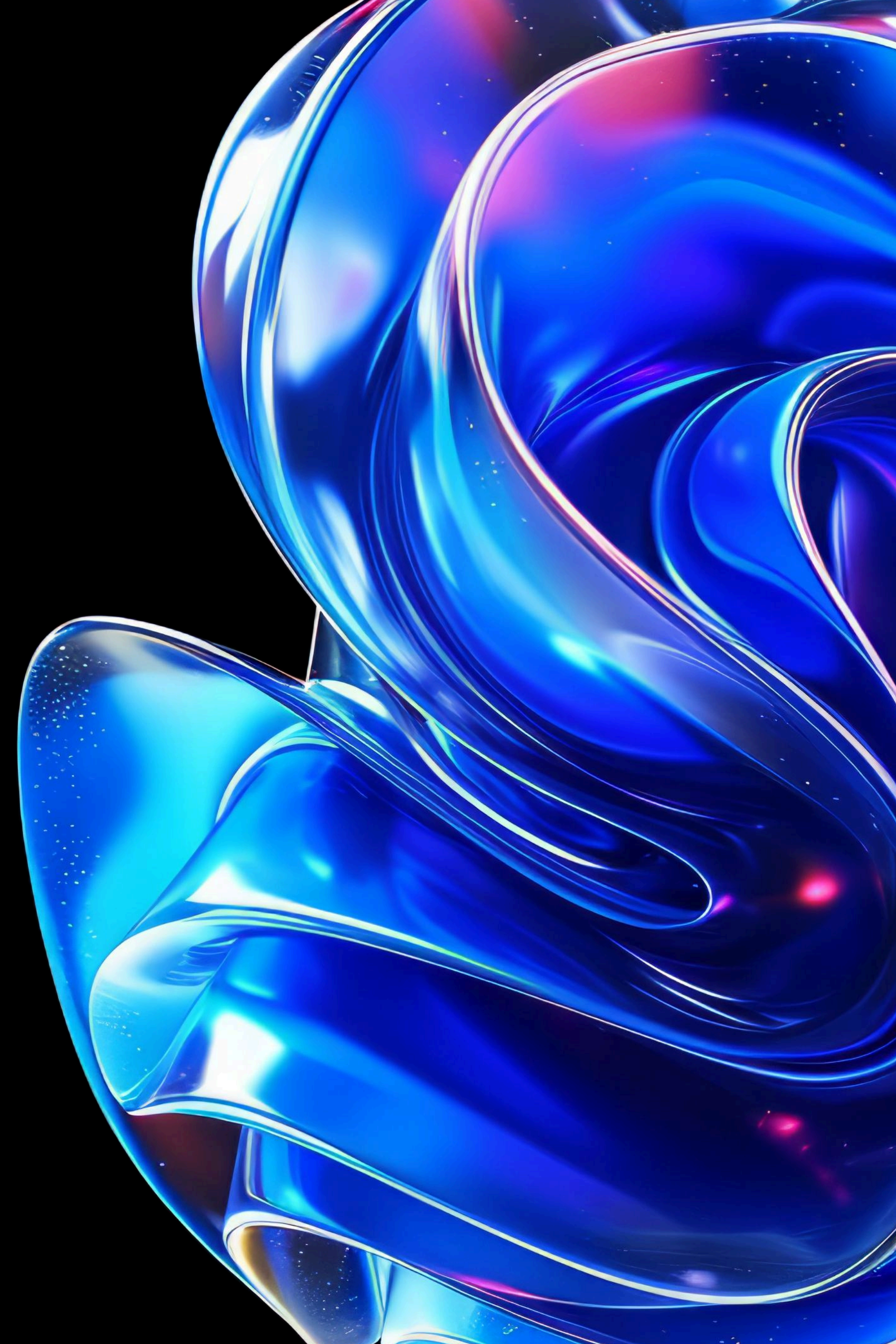


PRDC 2026

Designing for AI with AI

September 22 2026

Maria Volkova | Neovation

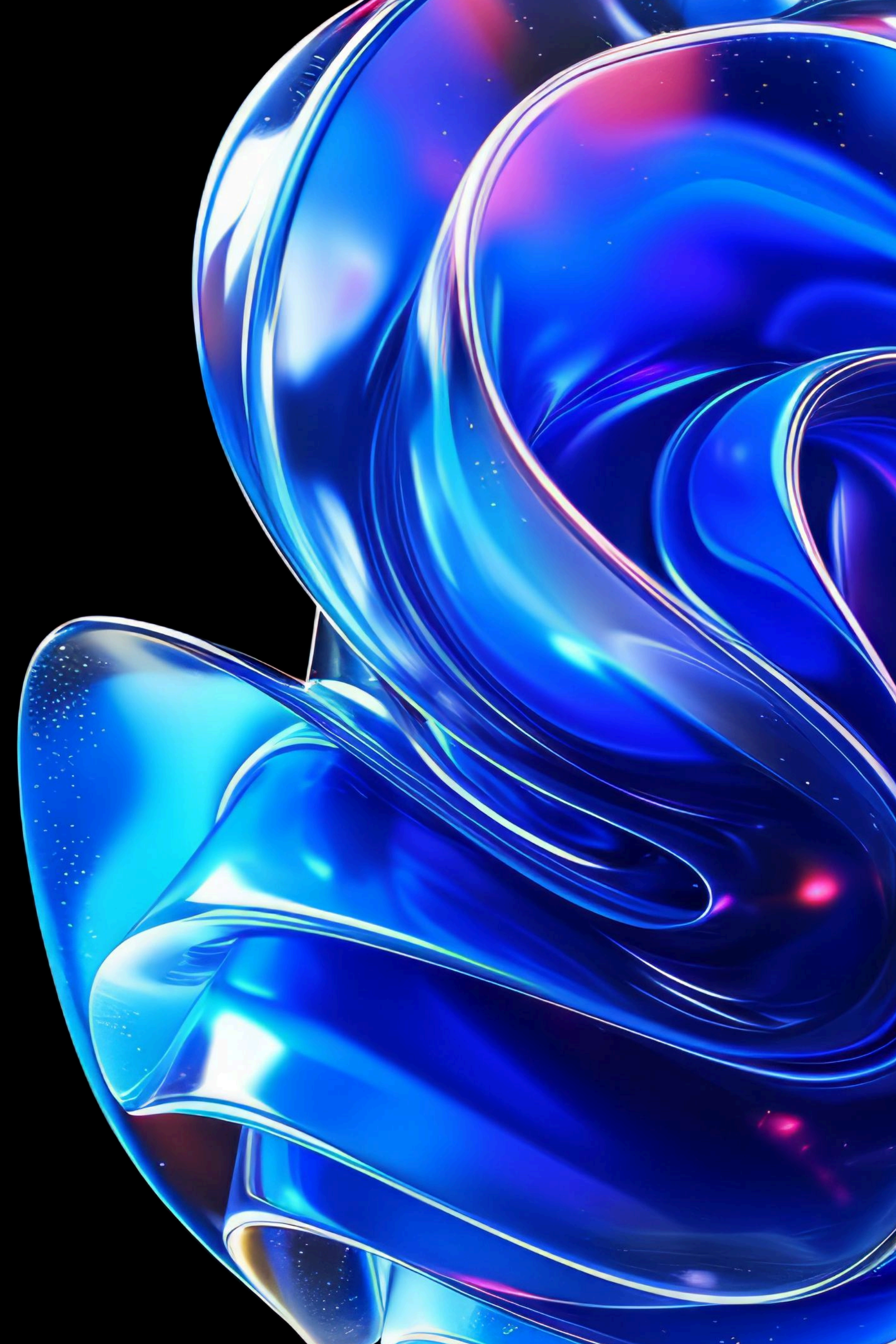


PRDC 2026

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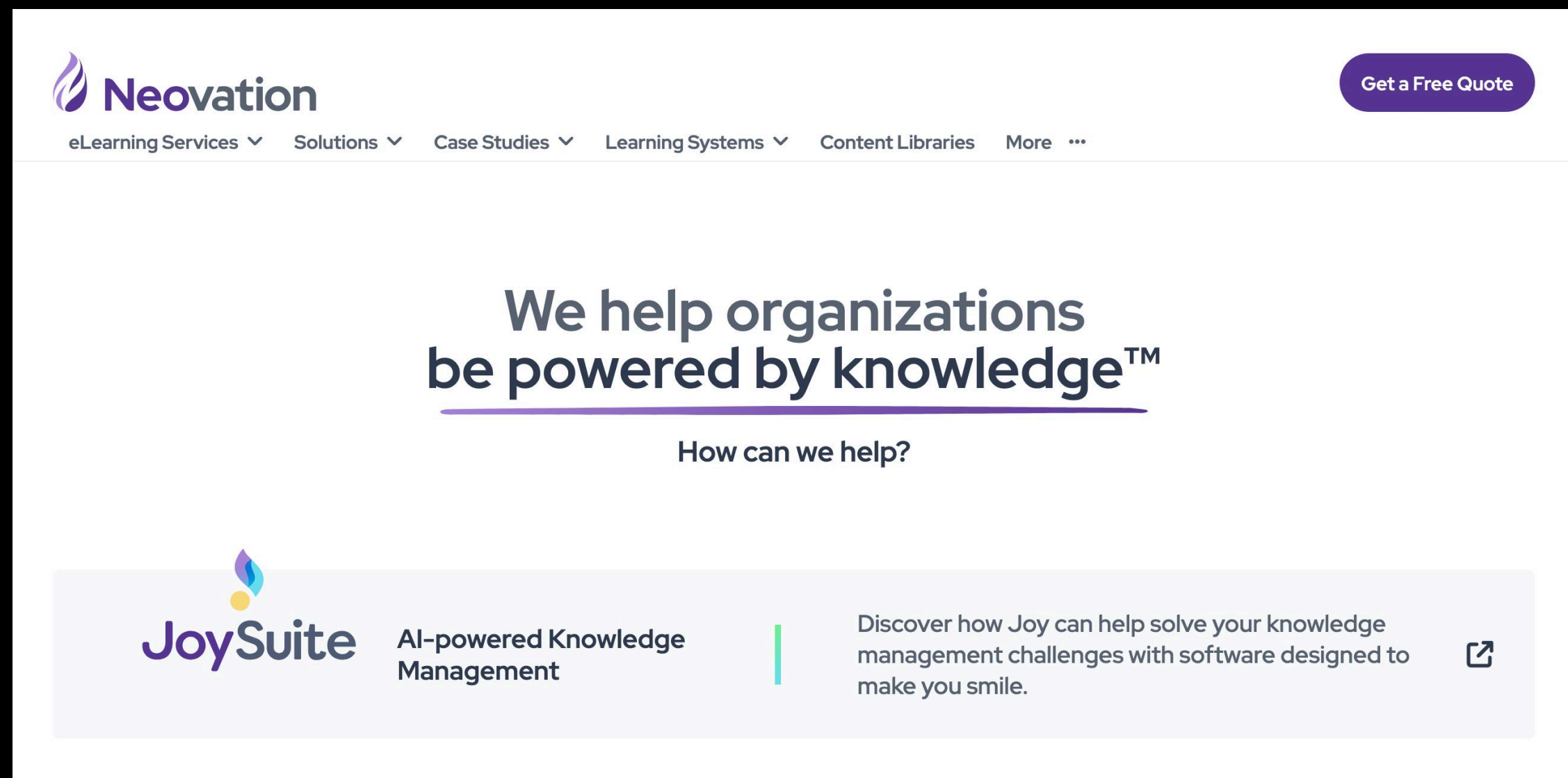


Maria Volkova

Senior UX Designer & Tech Lead at Neovation

Also a dancer, traveler, hiker, gardener, reader, artist, and much more!

- Designer since 2019
- RRC Grad
- AI skeptic
- and it's my birthday today!



Neovation

neovation.com

Award-winning B2B eLearning software and Services

Winnipeg company since 2012

PRAIRIE DEV CON

AI CLOUD IDEV DATA

Payworks



Google Public Sector | carahsoft.

improving
It's what we do.™

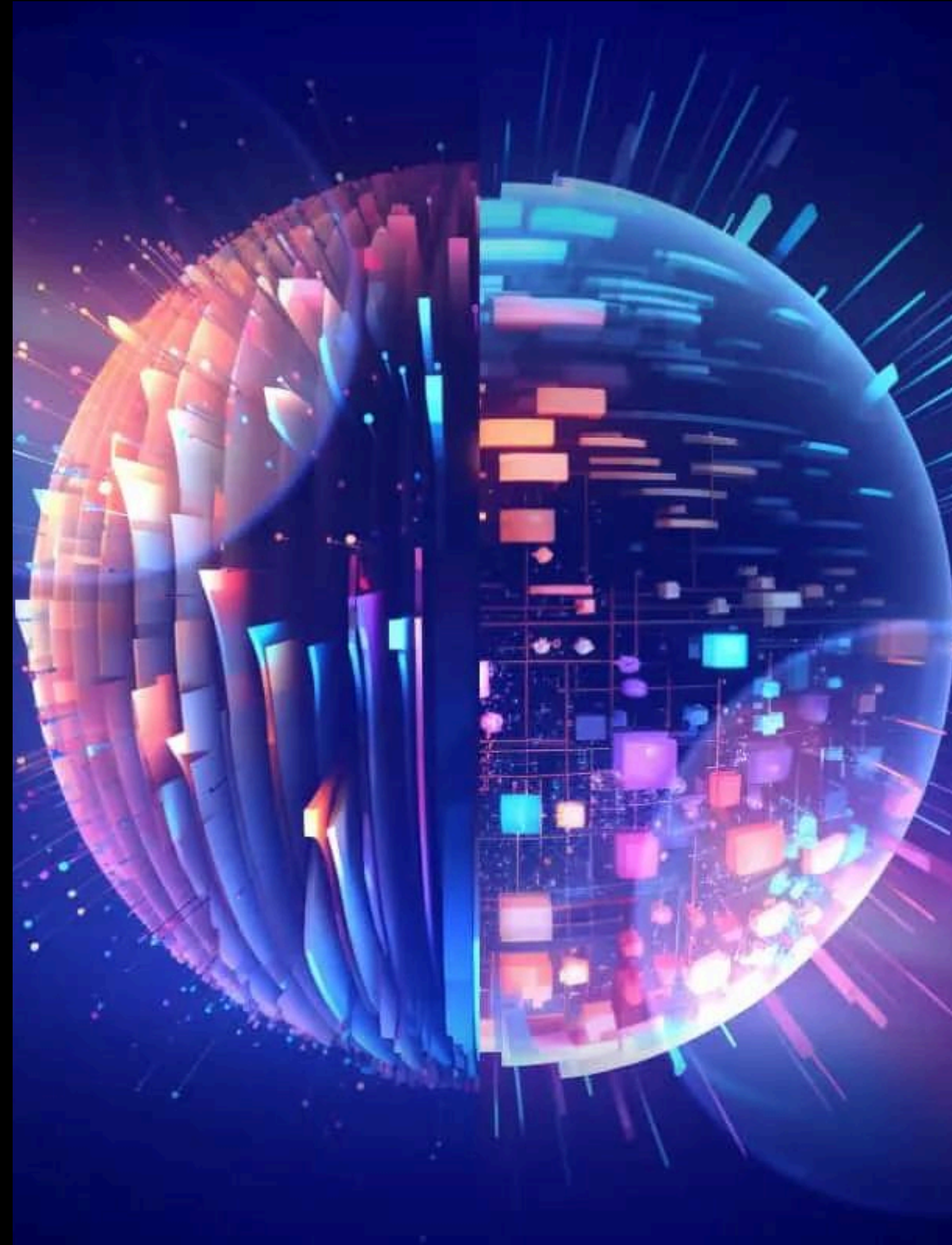
laivly

POLLARD
banknote limited

RICHARDSON

NMM New Media
Manitoba

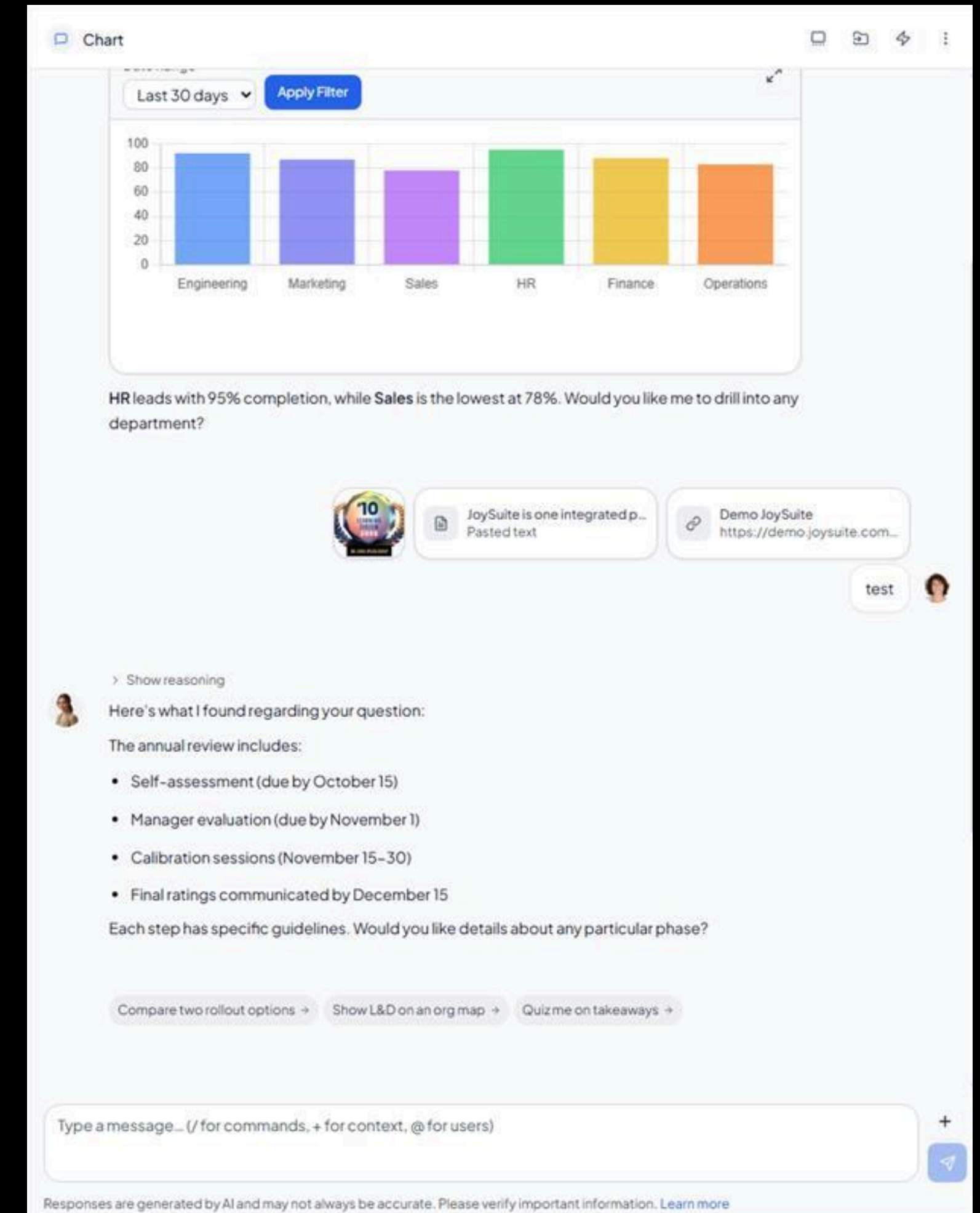
Definitions



AI tools we use

Generative AI LLMs

- ChatGPT
- Claude
- Cursor
- Gemini
- etc...



AI products we design

Chat-based interfaces where the user is interacting with an LLM in real time.



**What % of your day
to day work uses AI?**



For us, it is $>90\%$

Neovation in 2020

- Fully remote
- Small UX team
- Low design maturity
- Dev team of ~8
- Starting to figure out better processes
- Thinking about the next product...





JoySuite AI

Mission:
Next generation of eLearning

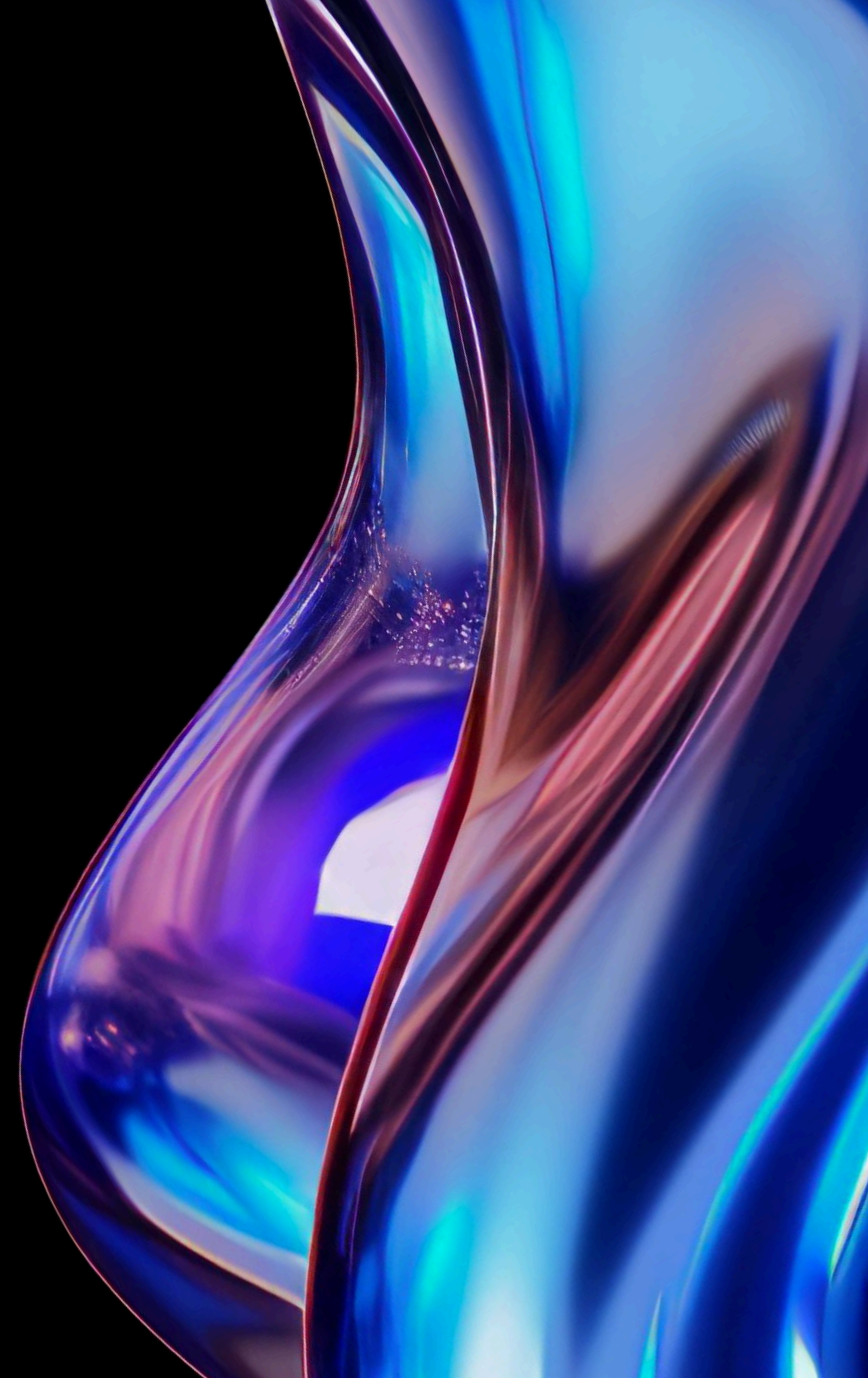
The AI Shift of 2022

- Early adopters of emerging LLM tools
- Watching the eLearning market
- Big change in direction for new product

The ground was shifting beneath our feet.

The AI-native mandate asked everyone at the company to integrate AI tools anywhere we could.

This included the support teams, sales teams, product and design, marketing, **EVERYONE.**





**We tried to use AI to
do what humans did.**

How we work now

- AI-native product development
- Designing in code
- Separate sandbox repo for UX to design
- Always optimizing for cost
- RSI (Recursive self-improvement)
- Working in formats that LLMs are good at



Demo App Stack & Environment

- React
- Tailwind + RadixUI primitives
- TinyBase
- Github repo
 - Feature branches
 - Development branch
 - Live

Design Process

①

Feature Brief

- business requirements,
- general idea of functionality
- integration with existing features
- value proposition

Gemini

②

Ideation

- get many ideas out quickly
- see real UI
- refine flows & interactions

Figjam

Gemini

Cursor

③

Iteration & Testing

- gather feedback from team
- iterate and refine
- review with team

Gemini

Cursor

④

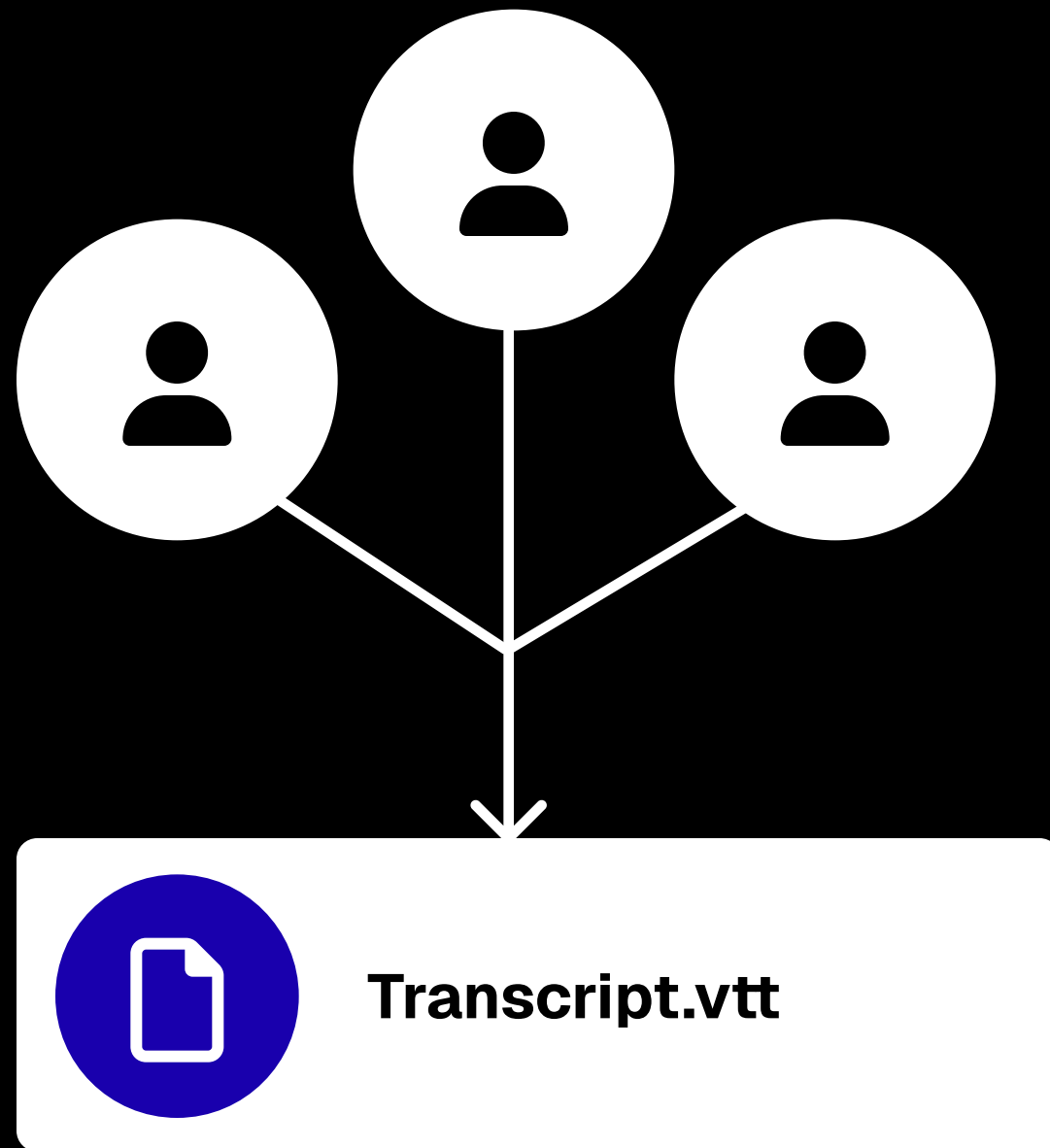
Plan & Handoff

- summarize design intent
- document decisions & UI flows
- give dev & QA a good understanding of what we're building

Cursor

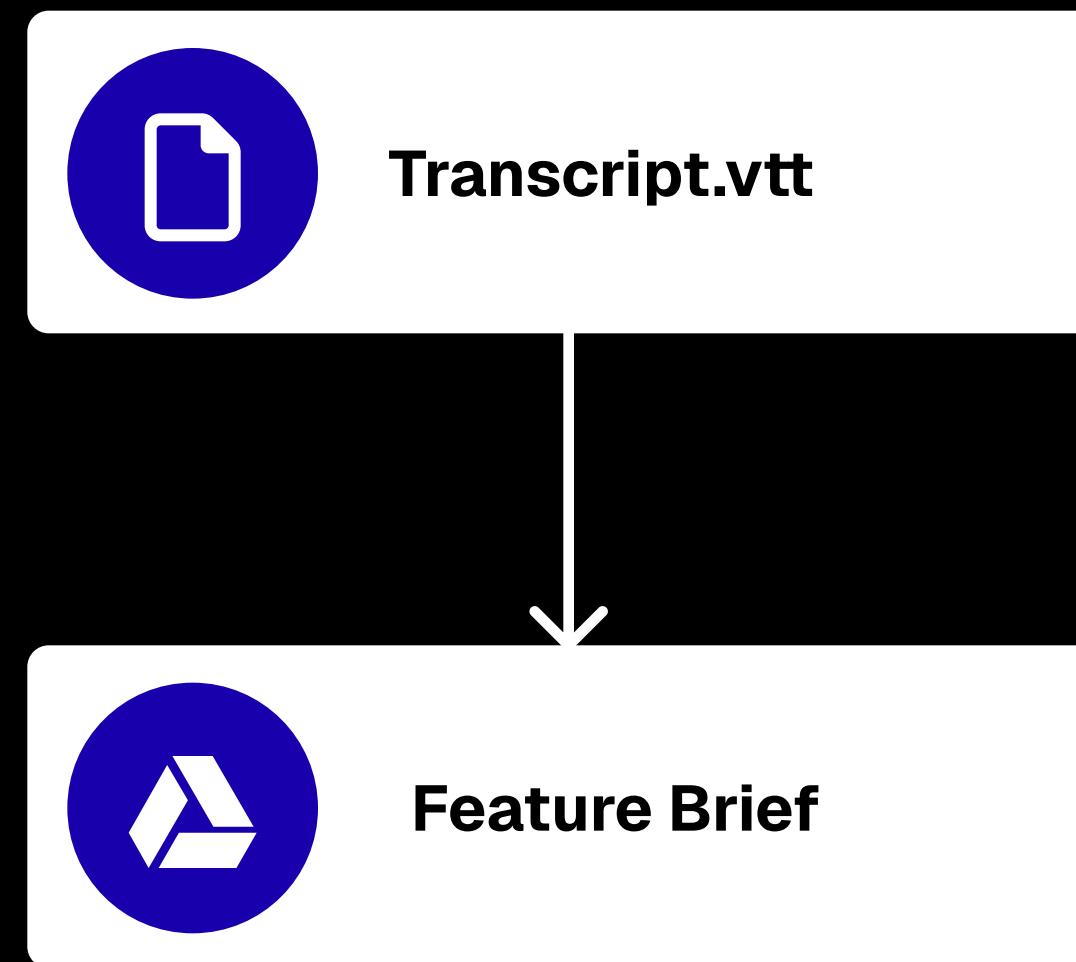
Coderabbit

① Feature Brief



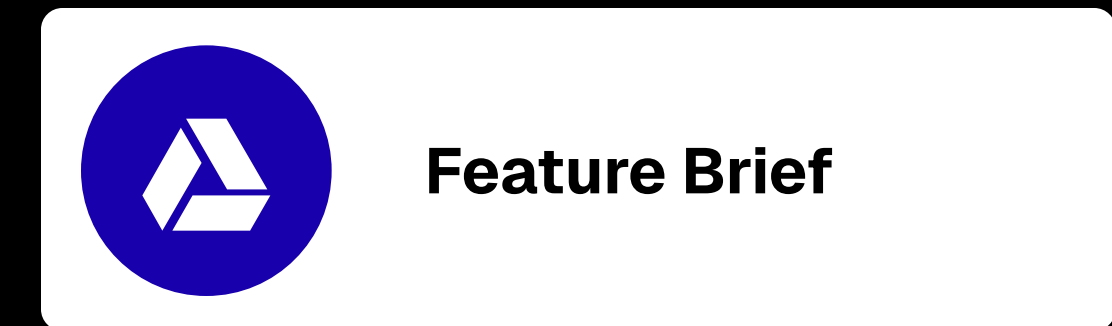
Meeting and discussion

- Input: Product owner's ideas/notes
- Process: Live team discussion
- Output: Transcript



Gemini processes transcript

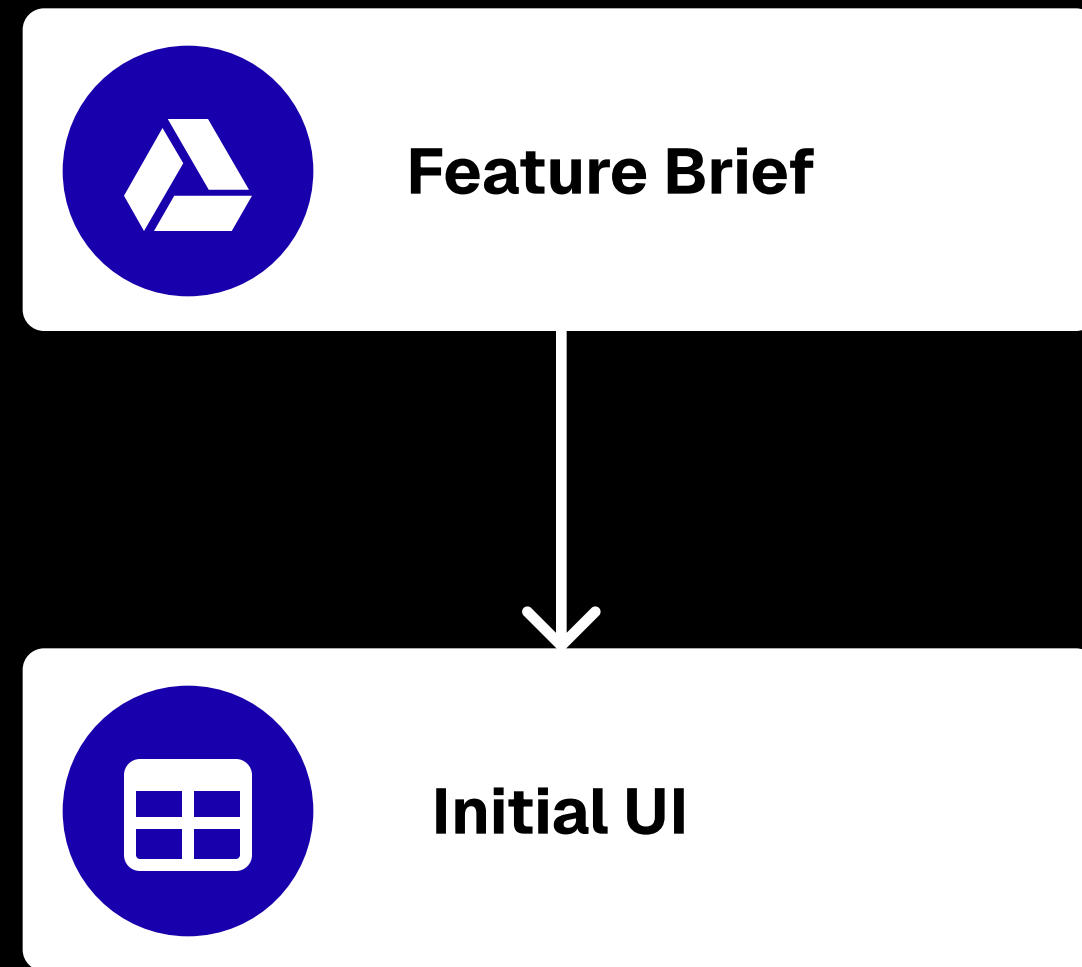
- Input: Transcript
- Process: Gemini Gem
- Output: Feature Brief



Generated brief is ready to be used

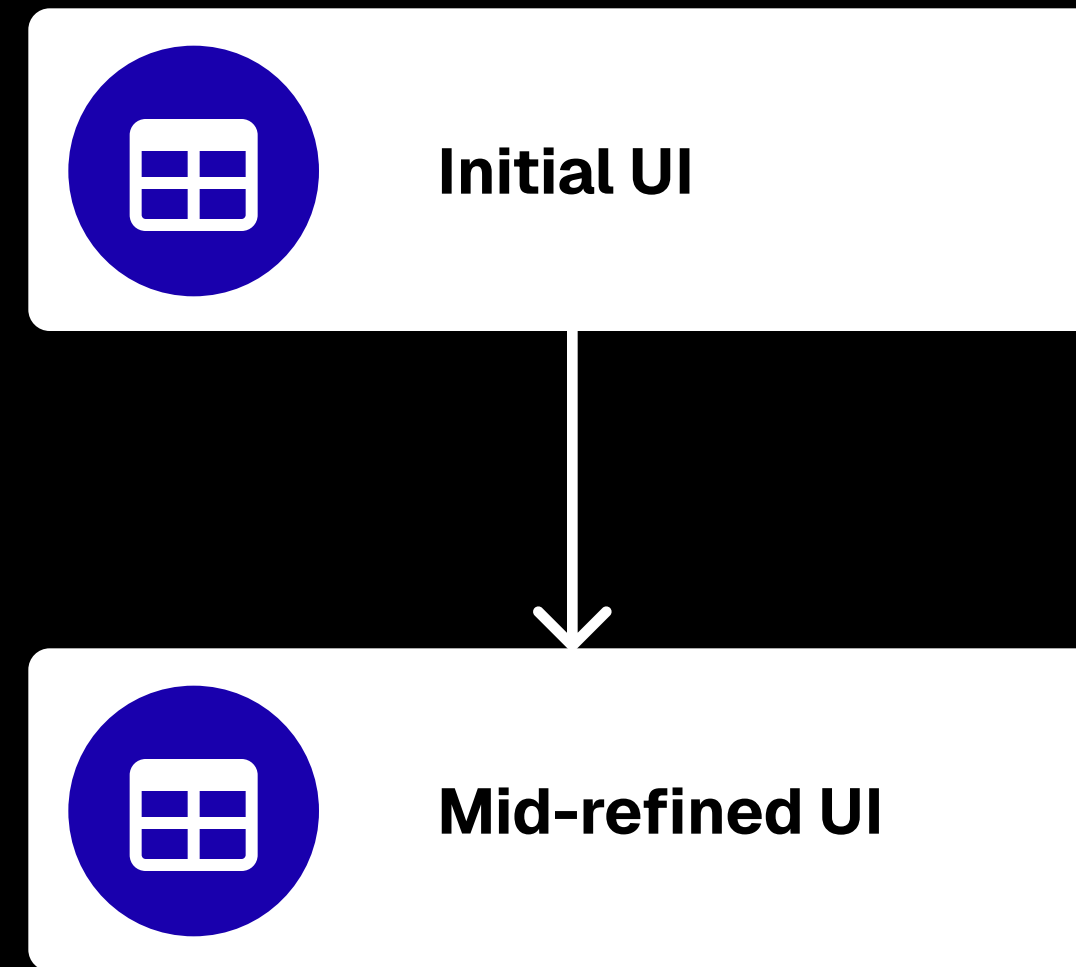
The brief is stored in a Google doc until a designer is ready to start working on the feature.

② Ideation



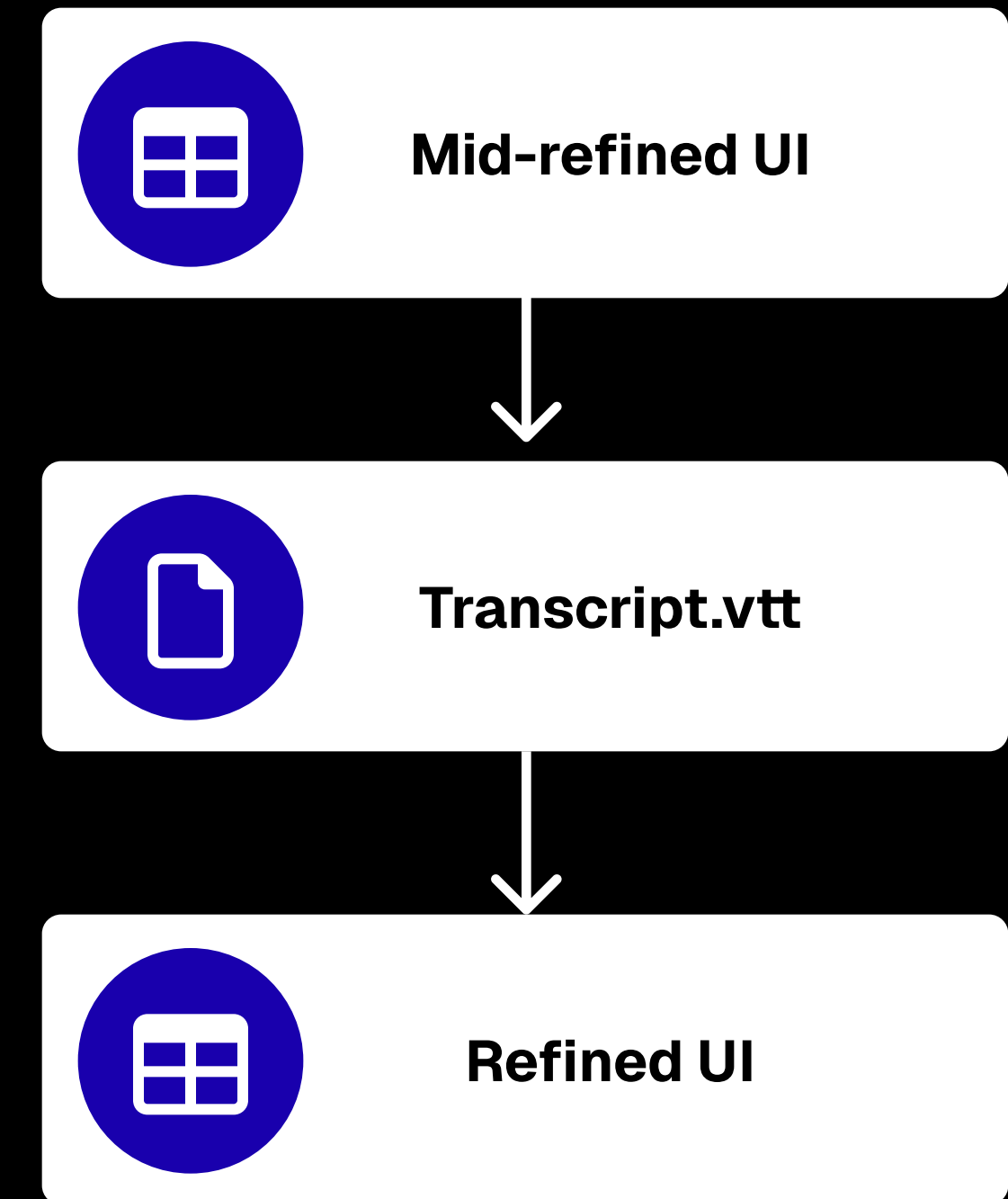
Brief is used by Cursor command

- Input: Feature Brief
- Process: Cursor command
- Output: Initial UI



Look at the output and make edits

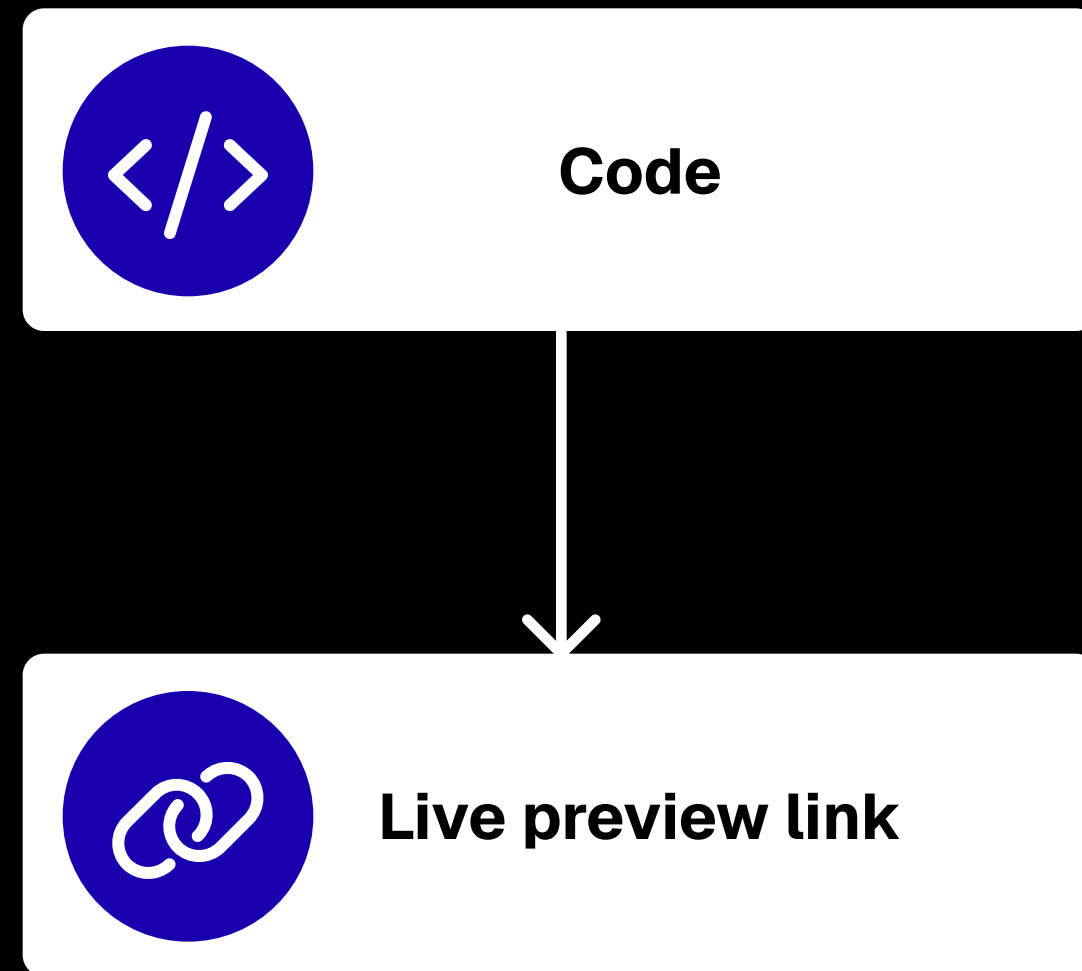
- Input: Initial UI
- Process: Manual review and prompting
- Output: Mid-refinement UI



Discuss in calls and feed transcript notes back in

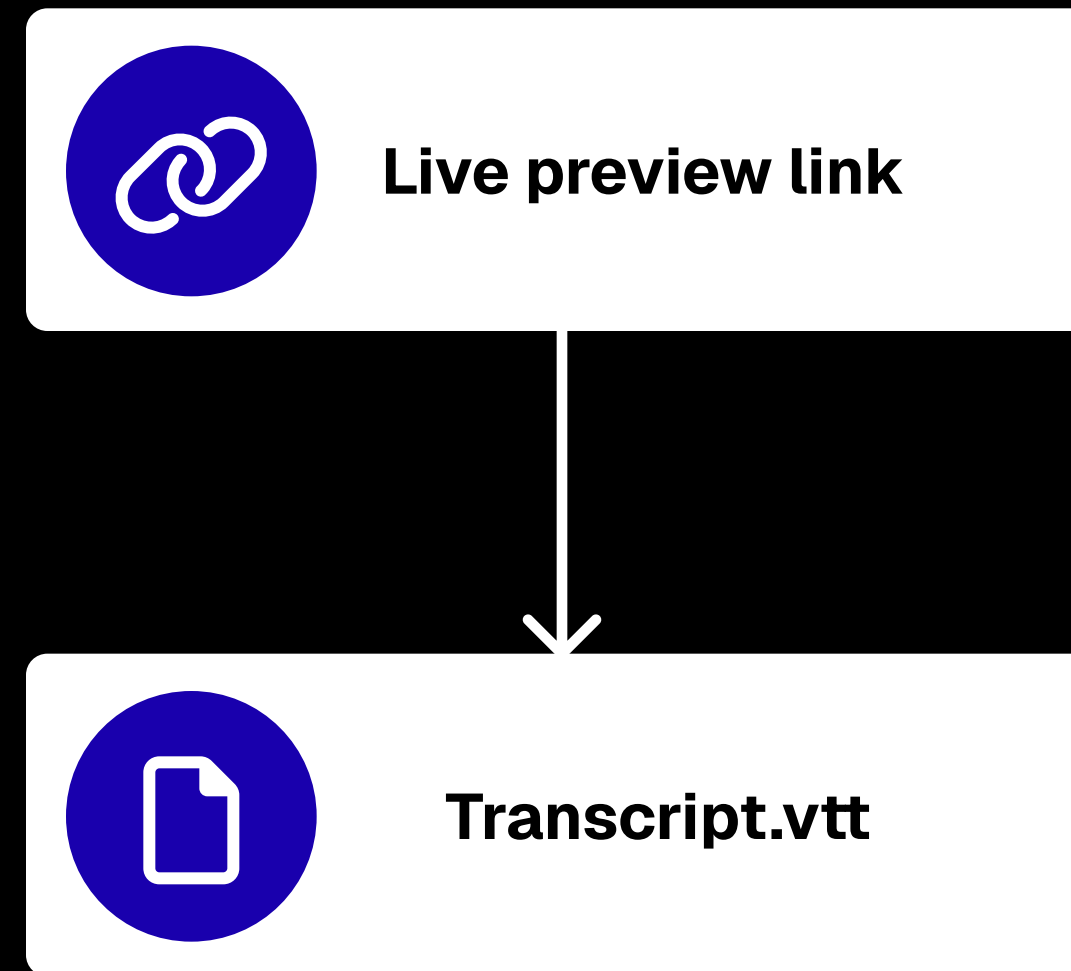
- Input: Mid-refinement UI
- Process: Live team discussion
- Output: Call notes and revisions
- Final output: Refined UI

③ Iteration & Testing



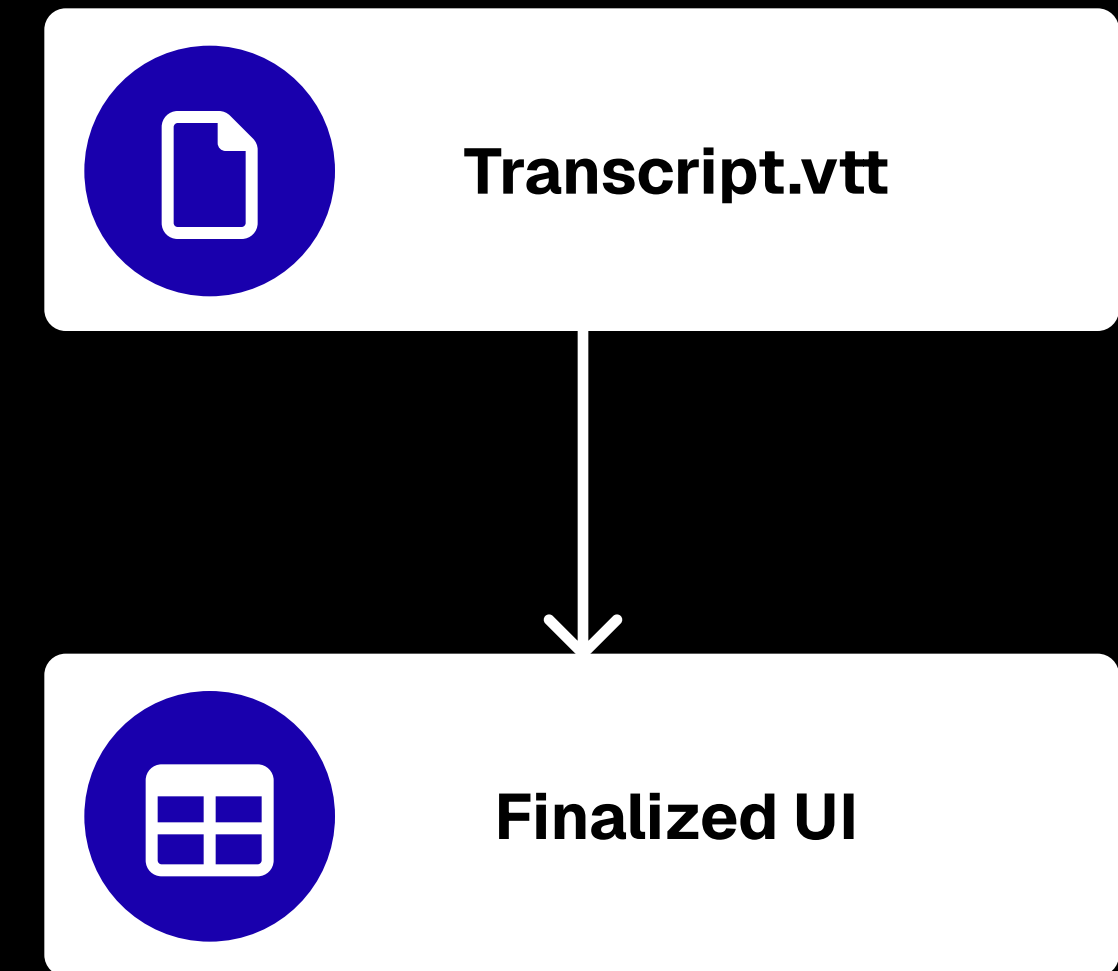
Deploy preview of branch

- Input: Committed code
- Process: create PR and auto-deploy with Vercel
- Output: Live, hosted preview branch



Gather internal feedback

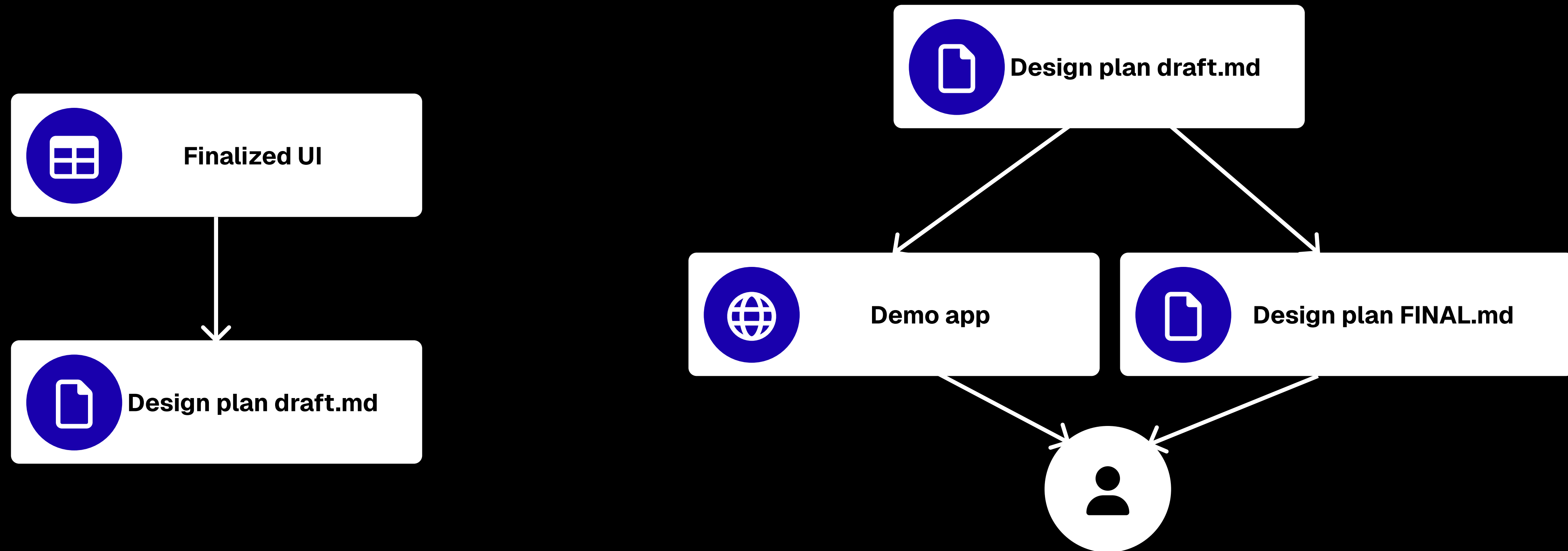
- Input: Refined UI, hosted preview
- Process: Live team discussion
- Output: Call notes and revisions



Iterate using Cursor

- Input: Call notes transcript
- Process: Summarize notes and give to cursor, manual prompting
- Output: Finalized UI

④ Plan & Handoff



Cursor command to generate design plan

- Input: Refined UI
- Process: Cursor command
- Output: Draft of design plan

Approve plan, release to demo

- Input: Draft of design plan
- Process: manual team review, PR review
- Output: Finalized design plan, live demo release

Hand off design plan to developer

- Input: Finalized design plan, live demo
- Process: live handoff call
- Output: Devs & QA know what's up!



What we've learned

Mental load of AI

- It feels less satisfying
- Reviewing AI work is harder than it seems
- More projects are running in parallel
- Artifact is not process
- When easy tasks are automated, what is left?
→ AI Brain Fry

Rendered UI is only part of the experience

- Instructions as UX
- Generative UI
- Interaction design for non-deterministic outputs
- Testing and QA of dynamic UI

Designers have to be more technical

- Understanding how LLMs work is essential
- Prompting is a real skill
- Context is content

Uncharted waters of AI products

- Flood of new tools
- Convergent evolution

Emerging Patterns

Context

Adding files to the context of the prompt for more accurate and targeted results.

Commands & Tools

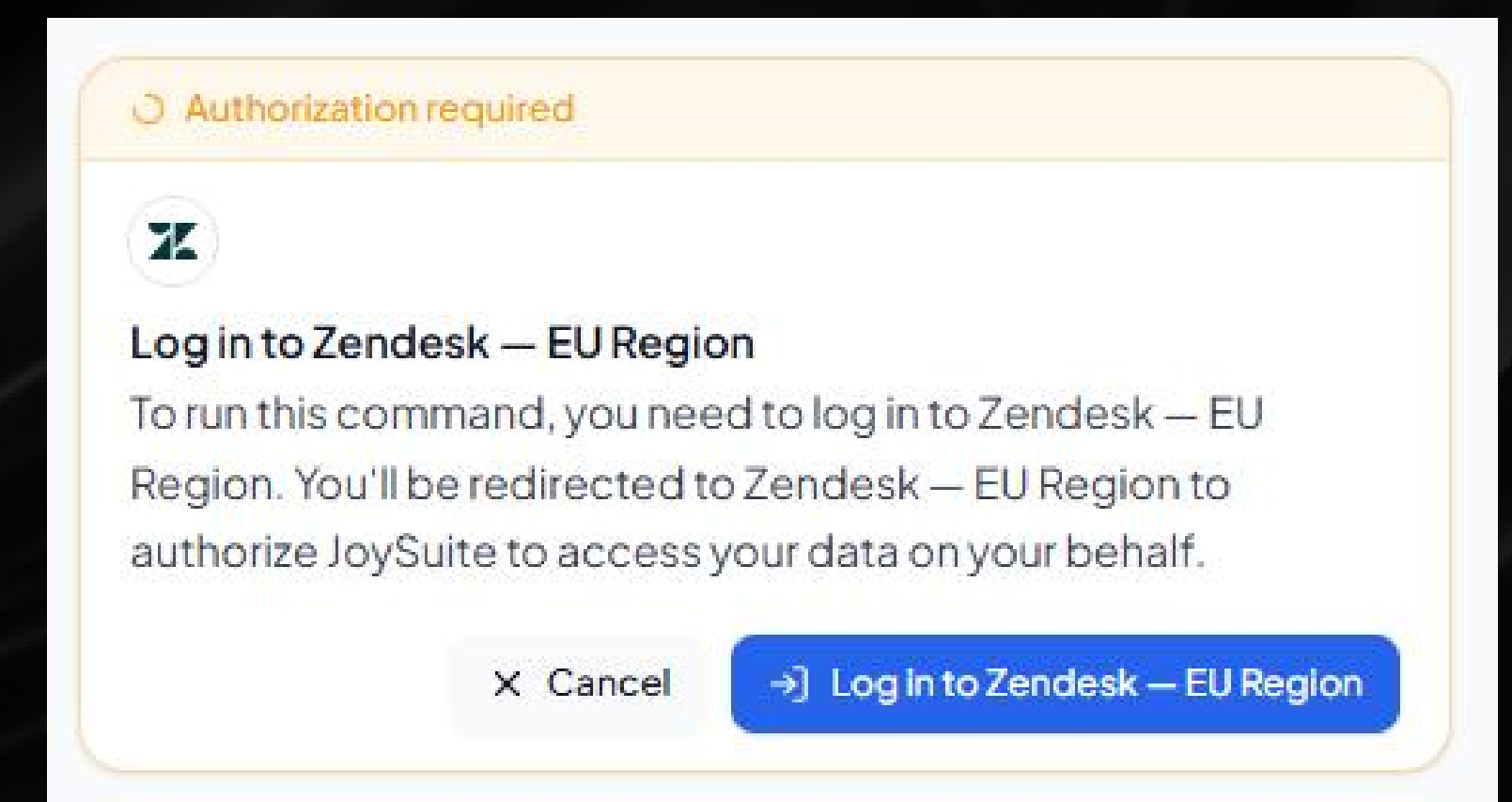
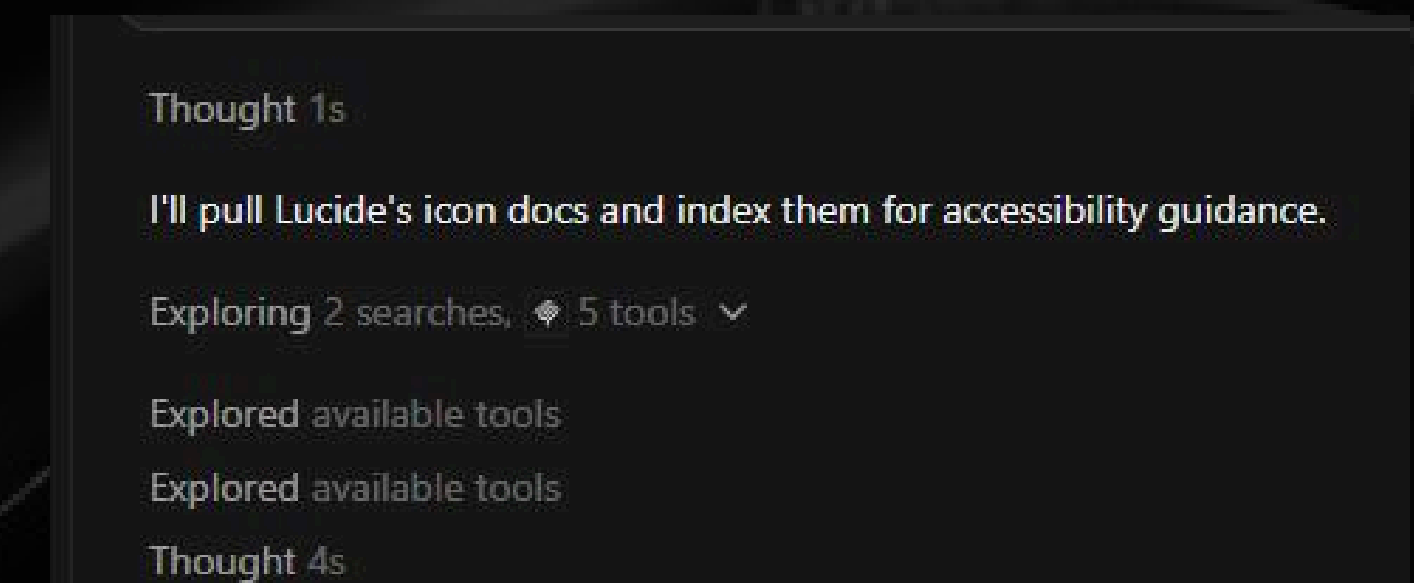
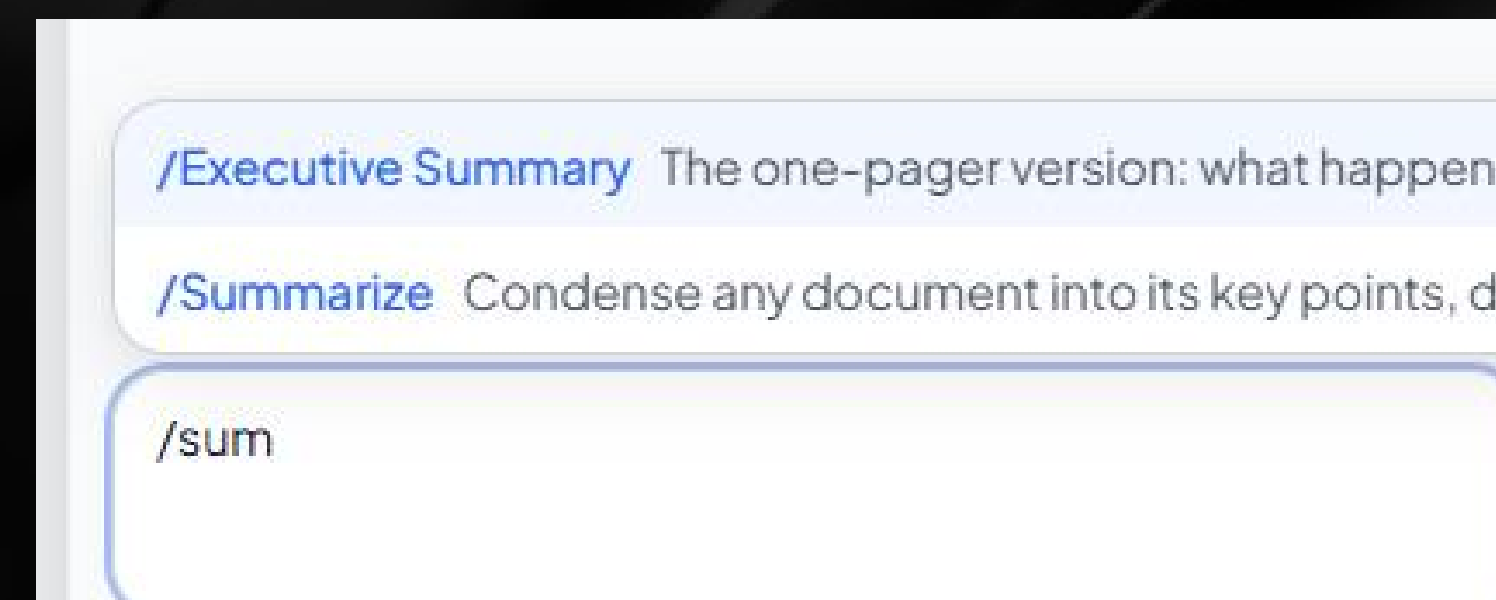
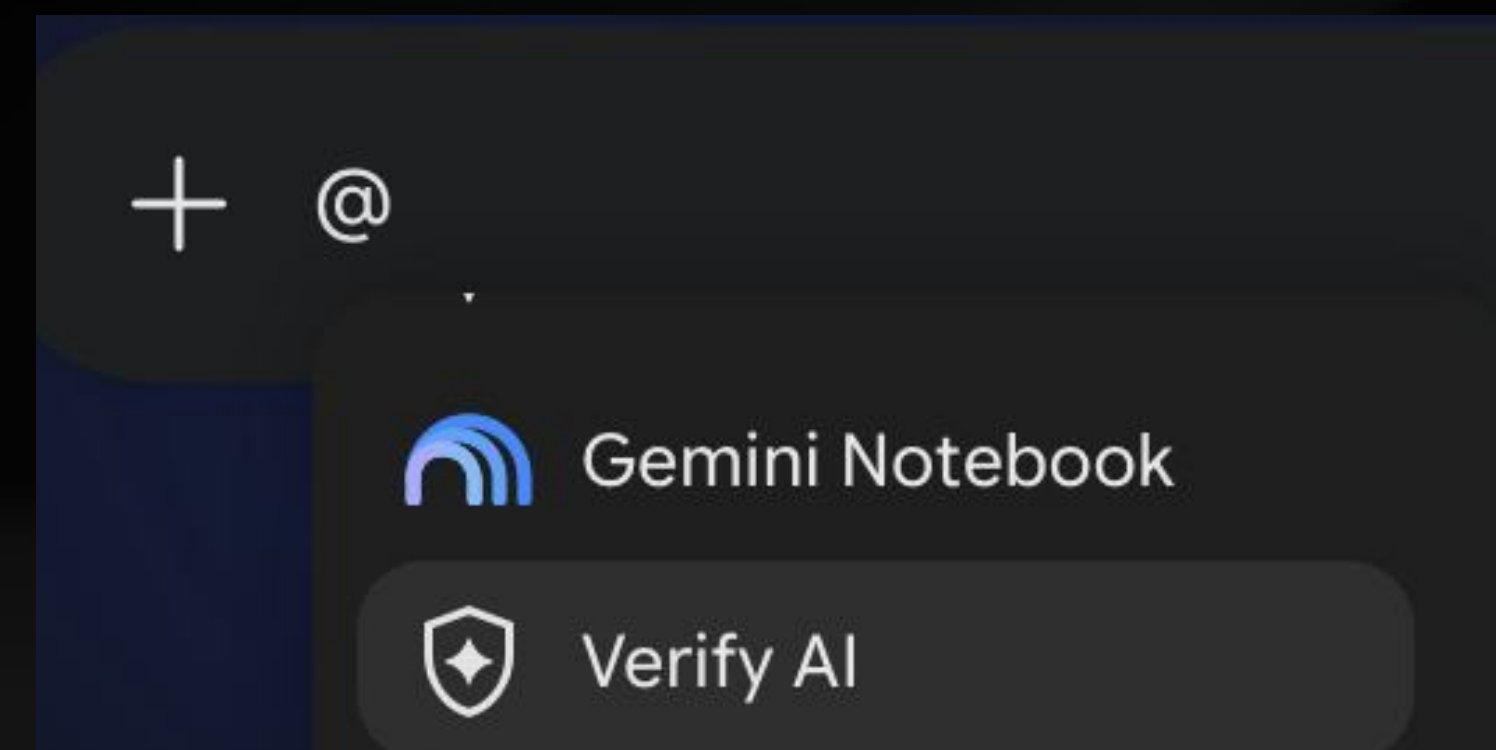
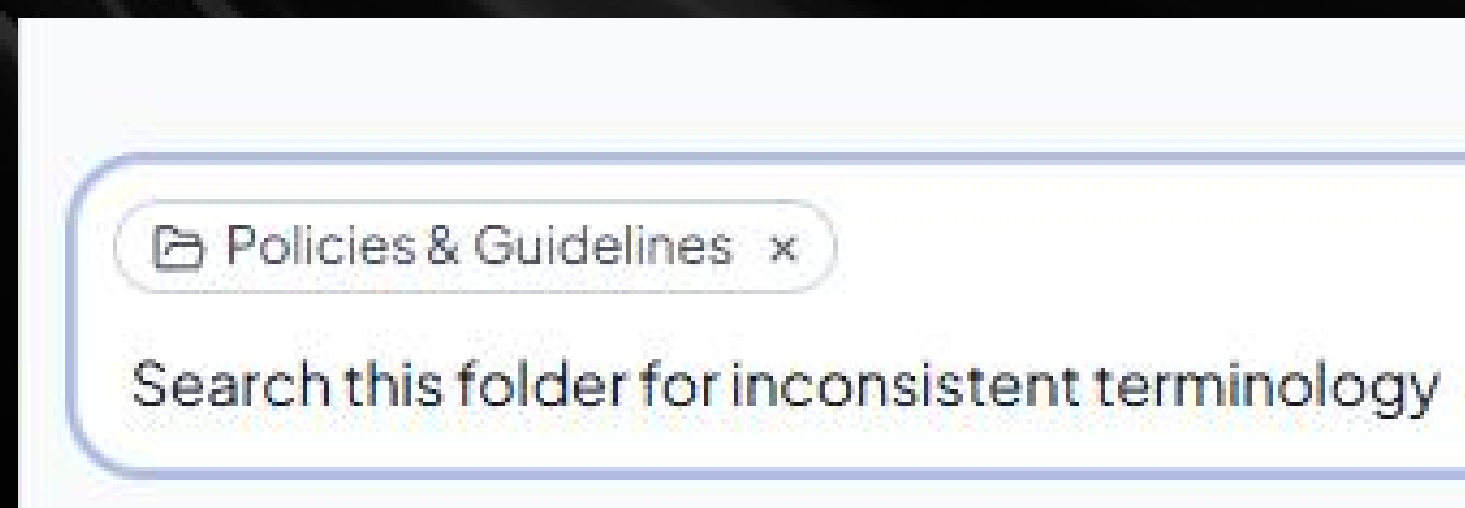
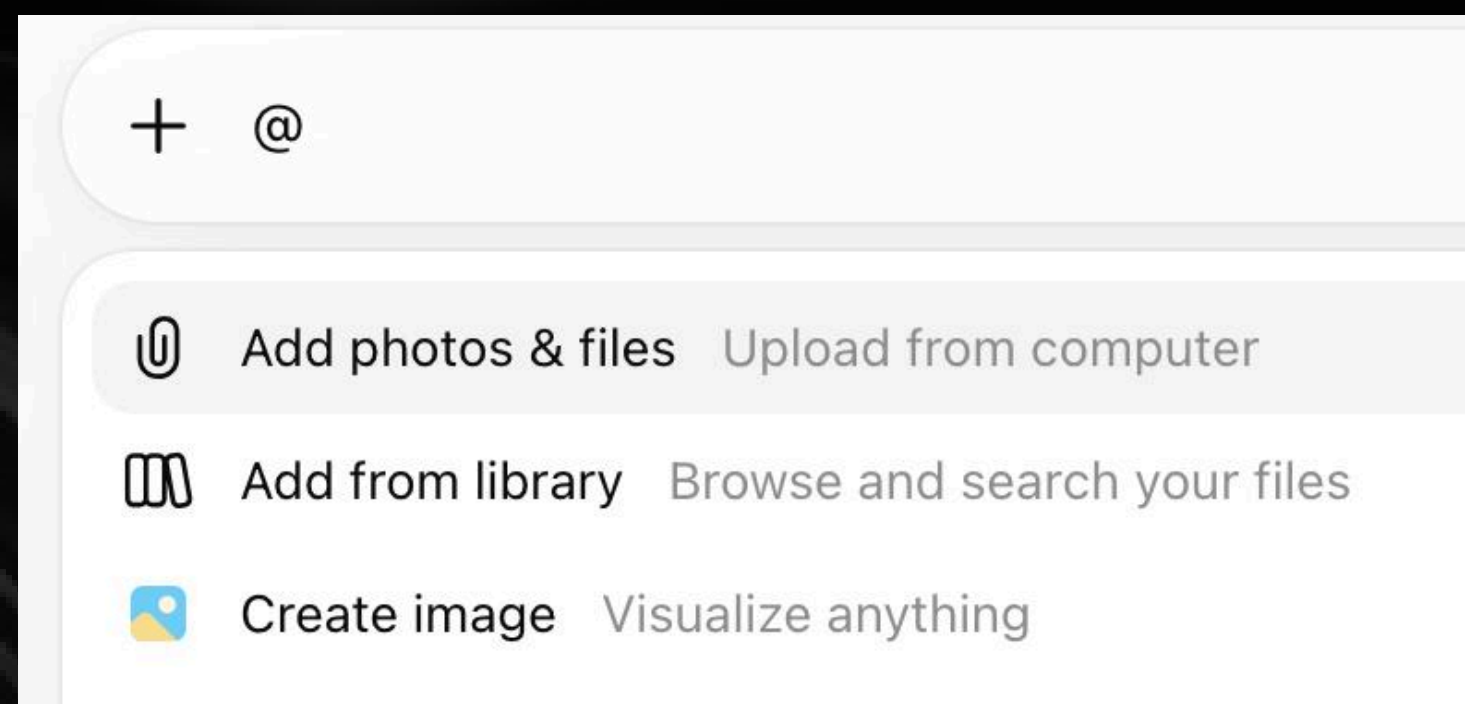
Saving prompt instructions to be reused, or using pre-configured slash commands in the chat.

Calling specific 3rd party tools into the chat.

HITL & Reasoning

Waiting for human confirmation before performing a potentially risky action.

Surfacing the inner workings of the LLM process.



Uncharted waters of AI products

- Flood of new tools
- Convergent evolution
- Playing catch-up
- AI-ception

Adoption hurdles of AI products

- Negative user sentiment
- Lack of transparency
- Blank page problems

Takeaways

How AI has helped us

①

Acceleration

We are able to output a lot more designs in the same time.

②

Flexibility

We can pivot and change direction faster and easier.

③

Elevated capabilities

We can augment our skills, and move away from relying on 3rd party UI.

④

Documentation

We spend less time manually writing and maintaining documentation.

How AI has harmed us

①

Mental impact

Burnout and AI brain fry.

②

Costs

We spend a lot on tokens.

③

Creativity

We are relying less and less on ideas that originate in our own heads.

④

Knowledge

We are not as motivated to learn new coding or design methods.

Other lessons

①

AI is an emotional topic

This doesn't mean we should dismiss it as "irrational". Instead, we must treat it with empathy.

②

The structure of work is shifting

Individual contributors are now managing multiple agents as if they were their own little teams.

③

Design is democratized

When anyone can come to a meeting with a high fidelity mockup of their idea, the conversation shifts focus.

④

The signal through the noise

AI is being shoved into everything. Users are getting tired and struggling to see value.



**So what have we
designed?**

PMI Delta Engineering

Assistant

Knowledge Center

Tasks

Feedback Center

Management Center

Account Center

Tamar Lomidze
Owner

My Library

My Library

Search... (/)

Filter 14 Name

My Library

People & Culture

Tech & Tools

New Hire Setup

Software Guides

Sales

Untitled Course

Untitled Course

miss events, and corrective actions...

Leadership Management

+1 more

NRC Compliance — Scenario Coaching

Role-play a mock NRC audit interview with Dr. Mercer as PMI Delta's RSO...

PMI Onboarding Learning Path

A four-section onboarding curriculum covering HR essentials, workplace...

Onboarding New Hire

Project Portfolio Dashboard

Project Schedule: Westfield Nuclear Upgrade (PRJ-001)

Radiation Safety — Annual Refresher

Annual refresher on radiation safety procedures, updated regulatory...

Radiation Safety — Module A

Foundational radiation safety training covering ALARA principles, dose limits...

Residential Solar Installation Process

Field guide for technicians covering safety protocols, component setup...

Safety Incident Log

Team Building Basics

A practical introduction to team building — covering team stages...

Team Building Collaboration

+1 more

Training Completion Metrics

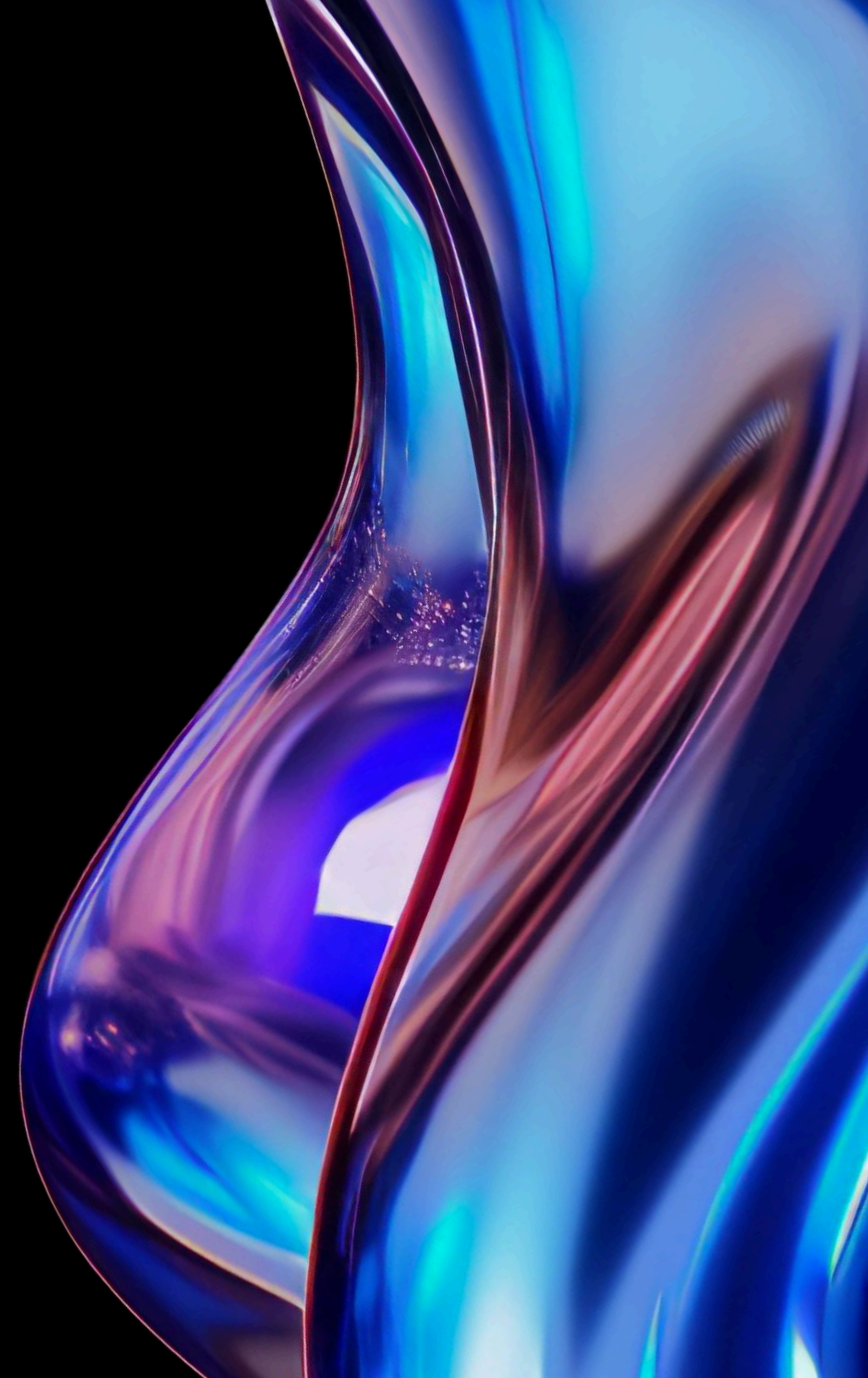
JoySuite Webinar



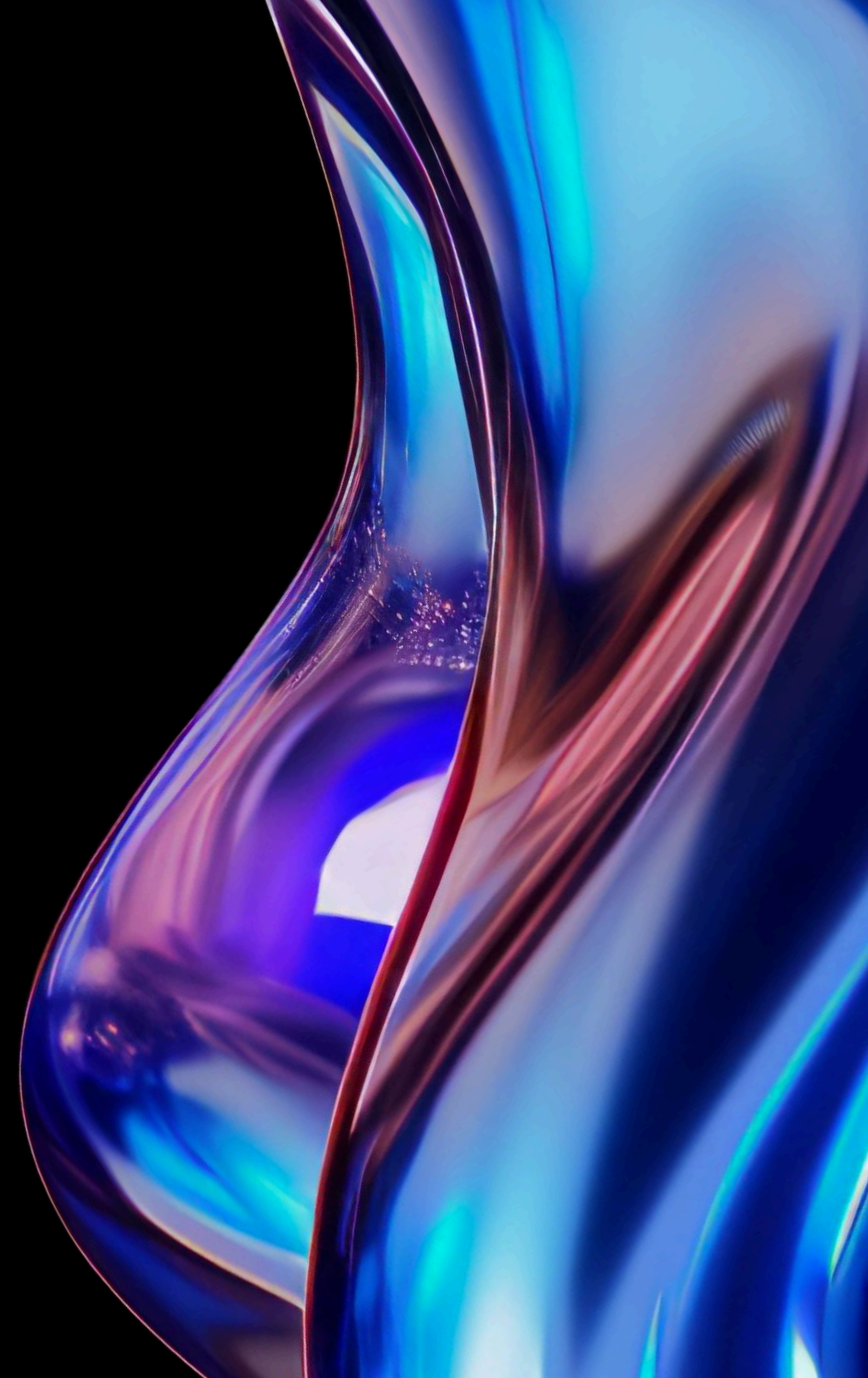


**Questions we have
yet to answer...**

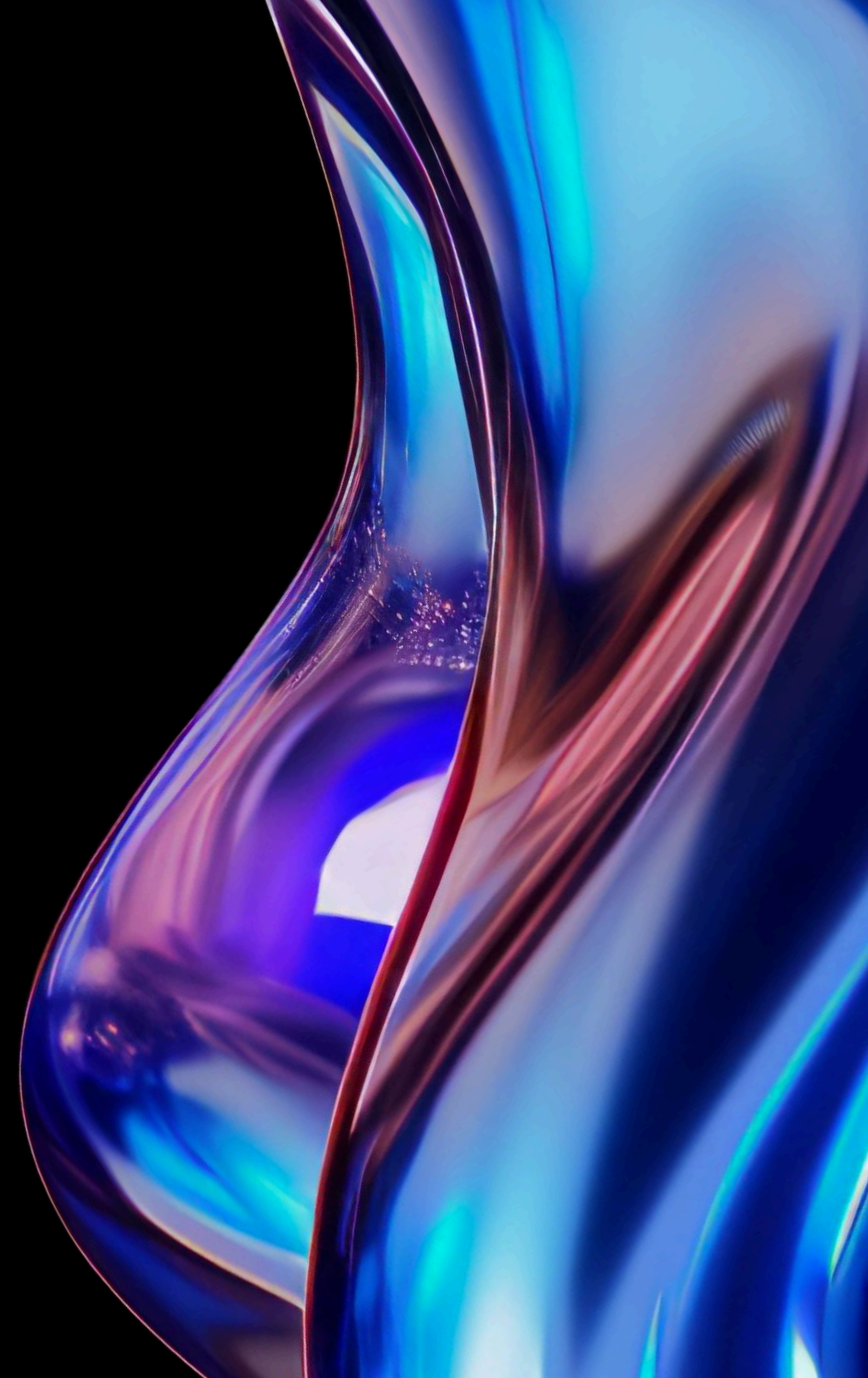
What will the designer's toolkit
look like in the next 5 years?



How do we build the future by
looking at the past?



Will user sentiment towards AI
continue the downward trend?



The background features abstract, flowing, liquid-like shapes in shades of blue and purple, primarily located in the top right and bottom left corners, set against a solid black background.

**My hope for the
future of AI products**

**A world where products
empower, enhance, and allow
users to reap real benefits of
integrated agentic systems,
dynamic interfaces, and
accurate, verified answers.**

Thank you!

Reading List:

<https://annaecook.com/writing/2026/designing-with-mustard>

<https://www.wheresyoured.at/>

<https://huyenchip.com/blog/>

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/designing-ai-study-guide/>

<https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2026/03/12/key-findings-about-how-americans-view-artificial-intelligence/>

<https://hai.stanford.edu/ai-index/2026-ai-index-report/public-opinion>

<https://time.com/7295195/ai-chatgpt-google-learning-school/>

